

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Social and Political Ideals - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

SOCIAL AND POLITICAL IDEALS

Philosophy Optional | Paper II | Socio-Political Philosophy | Topic 01

00 Printed clause boundary and the ideals triad OFFICIAL OWNER -> Equality, Justice and Liberty only EQUALITY asks in what respect persons must count as equals LIBERTY asks which protected choices and capacities agency requires JUSTICE asks what is due, by which rule and through	01 Individual claims and social institutions INDIVIDUAL EQUALITY -> equal moral worth and equal concern SOCIAL EQUALITY -> no arbitrary status hierarchy or inherited stigma INDIVIDUAL LIBERTY -> protected thought, choice and self-direction	02 Equality from formal status to substantive opportunity equal moral worth -> birth hierarchy bears the burden of justification formal or legal equality -> the same public legal status political equality -> citizenship, vote and eligibility for office
03 Rousseau Mill and Marx on socially produced inequality ROUSSEAU -> natural difference becomes domination through convention moral-political inequality -> wealth, honour, power and dependence MILL -> equal civic status and women's equality with individuality	04 Equality of what and the metric decision DWORKIN -> resources; brute luck differs from option luck SEN -> capability asks what persons are actually able to do and be conversion conditions make equal resources yield unequal freedom	05 Berlin Mill and the justified limit of coercion NEGATIVE LIBERTY -> freedom from interference POSITIVE LIBERTY -> self-direction and being one's own master Berlin warns against coercion for an alleged true or rational self MILL -> coercion needs prevention of harm to others
06 Law security autonomy and effective freedom HOBBS -> order secures residual liberty where law is silent LOCKE -> known law protects rights against arbitrary government ROUSSEAU -> autonomy is civic self-legislation through general will	07 Technology and republican non-domination technology expands communication, association and knowledge surveillance and platform dependence create standing power INTERFERENCE is an act; DOMINATION is uncontrolled capacity	08 Formal procedural and substantive justice FORMAL JUSTICE -> apply announced principles consistently PROCEDURAL JUSTICE -> fair hearing, publicity and impartial process SUBSTANTIVE JUSTICE -> just principle, distribution and status relation
09 Plato Aristotle utilitarianism and corrective repair PLATO -> harmony when each part performs its proper function objection -> functional harmony can freeze hierarchy ARISTOTLE DISTRIBUTIVE -> proportion by a relevant criterion criteria -> need, desert, merit, contribution,	10 Rawls Nozick Sen and Ambedkar RAWLS -> original position and veil model fair choice equal basic liberties have lexical priority fair equality of opportunity precedes the difference principle NOZICK -> acquisition, transfer and rectification, not a pattern	11 Fourteen PYQs and the executable answer spine OWNER CORPUS -> 14 verified parts across every year 2018-2025 DEFINE -> strongest sense of the ideal in the stem DISTINGUISH -> metric, interference, procedure, substance or repair ARGUE -> claim, named thinker or example, analysis,

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Social and Political Ideals - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

RAPID REVISION 1 - The Ideals Triad: Map, Working Thesis and the Ordering Problem

- Triad = Equality (in what sense equal?), Liberty (free from/for what?), Justice (what is due, by what rule?).
- Justice is the referee: it decides which inequalities are fair and which liberties are basic.
- Rivals only beyond a threshold; complementary at the level of basic liberties.
- Ordering verdict formula: "Liberty and equality are indispensable but each is indeterminate about which liberties and which equalities matter; justice is the criterion that orders their competing claims."

WRONG: Answering a composite stem with three separate mini-essays. Adjudicate the relation, do not just list.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 1-4 in Part II.

RAPID REVISION 2 - Equality I: Equal Worth, the Four Forms, Opportunity vs Outcome

- Equality = equal moral worth and equal concern; NOT identical talent or outcome.
- Four forms: formal/legal, political, social, economic (L-P-S-E).
- Formal equality without fair background conditions can entrench privilege.
- Opportunity (fair, not merely formal) vs outcome (thresholds, floors, least-advantaged), not flat levelling.

WRONG: Equating equality with sameness. That caps you at the average band.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 5-8 in Part II.

RAPID REVISION 3 - Equality II: Rousseau, Mill and Marx on Inequality, Individuality and Need

- Rousseau: natural (physical) vs artificial/moral (convention-made) inequality; the worst forms are socially produced.
- Mill: equal worth + civic equality + WOMEN'S equality, without crushing individuality; The Subjection of Women.
- Marx: formal equality hides exploitation; equity = differentiated shares by need; equal right can be a right of inequality.

WRONG: Treating "equity" and "equality" as synonyms in the Marxian question.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 9-12 in Part II.

RAPID REVISION 4 - Equality III: 'Equality of What?' -- Sen, Cohen and Dworkin

- The modern question is "equality of WHAT?": utility -> resources -> capabilities.
- Sen: capabilities (real freedom to do and be); conversion varies by person; open list via public reasoning.
- Cohen: just institutions can be undermined by an anti-egalitarian ethos.
- Dworkin: equalise resources; neutralise brute luck, respect option luck.

WRONG: Capability = utility, or capability = income. Both are wrong.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 13-16 in Part II.

RAPID REVISION 5 - Liberty I: Meaning, Berlin's Two Concepts, Mill's Harm Principle

- Negative liberty = freedom FROM interference (Hobbes, Locke, Mill).
- Positive liberty = freedom TO be self-directed (Rousseau, Kant, Green).
- Berlin's warning: the real-self/empirical-self split can license coercion.
- Mill's harm principle: coerce only to prevent harm to OTHERS; offence is not harm; it is a presumption for liberty.

WRONG: Saying Berlin rejects positive liberty outright.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 17-20 in Part II.

RAPID REVISION 6 - Liberty II: Hobbes, Locke, Rousseau, Green and the Liberty-Equality Relation

- Hobbes: free where law is silent (order first). Locke: free under known law, licence != liberty. Rousseau: free via the general will ("forced to be free").
- Green: positive/enabling freedom -- the power to do worthwhile things.
- Liberty vs equality: conflict beyond a threshold, complement at the base (equal basic liberties are themselves an equality).
- "How far" stems demand a conditional verdict, never a flat yes/no.

WRONG: Treating liberty and equality as permanent, level-independent enemies.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 21-24 in Part II.

RAPID REVISION 7 - Liberty III: Technological Society and Republican Non-Domination

- Tech society: liberty survives only with transparency, accountability and zones of non-domination; convenience != autonomy.
- Third family (Pettit): freedom as non-domination -- absence of another's capacity for ARBITRARY interference.
- Interference (act) != domination (standing capacity); non-arbitrary law is freedom-constituting.
- Pettit (1997) = theory; Skinner (1998) = history; no quotes, title+year only.

WRONG: Confusing an un-interfered-with dependent with a free person.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 25-28 in Part II.

RAPID REVISION 8 - Justice I: Meaning, Plato, Aristotle, the Criteria Problem and Corrective Justice

- Formal justice = consistent application; procedural justice = fair decision process; substantive justice = defensible principle, outcome and status order.
- Legal, political and socio-economic justice are distinct but connected; recognition enters here only as equal civic standing.
- Plato: justice = harmony; each part/class its own function.
- Aristotle: distributive (proportional equality) + corrective (arithmetic equality).
- Criteria problem: need / desert / merit / contribution / equal share / compensation -- one per sphere; injustice = exporting a criterion.
- Merit (forward, functional) != desert (backward, moralised).
- Compensatory principle: corrective justice generalised to structures; concede terminus + over-inclusion.

WRONG: Reducing justice to "whatever the law says"; legality is not legitimacy.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 29-32 in Part II.

RAPID REVISION 9 - Justice II: Rawls, Nozick, Sen, Ambedkar and the Ordering Verdict

- Rawls: original position + veil -> equal basic liberties (FIRST) -> fair equality of opportunity -> difference principle (benefit the least advantaged); reflective equilibrium.
- Nozick: justice in holdings = acquisition + transfer + rectification; historical not patterned; Wilt Chamberlain; minimal state.
- Sen: niti (rules) vs nyaya (realised justice); comparative not transcendental; capabilities + public reasoning.
- Ambedkar: liberty + equality + FRATERNITY; social democracy underwrites political democracy.
- Ordering verdict: liberty + equality indispensable but indeterminate; justice orders them.

WRONG: "Rawls's first principle is equality." It is equal LIBERTY (lexically prior).

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 33-36 in Part II.

RAPID REVISION 10 - Debates, Criticisms and Traps: Synthesis Across the Triad

- Debates: Berlin/Green, Rawls/Nozick, Rawls/Sen, Mill/Marx, Plato-Aristotle-Rawls. Compare on shared axes; adjudicate conditionally.
- Ten traps: sameness; Berlin; Mill-as-licence; Rousseau; Rawls-first-principle; Nozick-as-patterned; Sen-as-welfare-economics; Ambedkar-name-drop; justice=law; one-sided advocacy.
- Balanced evaluation = thesis + strongest counter-position + reasoned verdict.

WRONG: Two-biography comparisons and one-sided demolitions.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 37-40 in Part II.

CANONICAL EXAM APPARATUS (PRESERVED VERBATIM)

The examiner apparatus below is reproduced verbatim from the canonical Social-Political-Ideals.md (headings demoted, navigation links stripped). It is preserved intact so that no canonical depth - the keyword and statement bank, the corpus-driven depth delta, the PYQ routing table, the answer architecture with its directive decoder, selectable evidence bank and graded verdict formulas, the link-outs and the sources - is lost in the layered reorganisation.

Keyword and Statement Bank

7.1 Keywords

Promoted vocabulary (this pass) ANALYSIS:: non-domination · arbitrary interference · freedom as status · benevolent master · contestability · interest-tracking law · merit · desert · need · contribution · equal share · sphere-sensitivity · morally arbitrary advantage · corrective justice · compensatory principle · transmitted disadvantage

- equal moral worth FACT:
- formal/legal equality FACT:
- substantive equality ANALYSIS:
- equality of opportunity FACT:
- equality of outcome ANALYSIS:
- equity / need-sensitive distribution ANALYSIS:
- natural vs moral inequality FACT:
- negative liberty FACT:
- positive liberty FACT:
- harm principle FACT:
- self-regarding / other-regarding FACT:
- self-realisation FACT:
- distributive justice FACT:
- corrective / rectificatory justice FACT:
- proportional equality FACT:
- original position FACT:
- veil of ignorance FACT:
- equal basic liberties FACT:
- fair equality of opportunity FACT:
- difference principle FACT:
- reflective equilibrium FACT:
- entitlement theory FACT:
- patterned vs historical principles FACT:
- minimal state FACT:
- institutional justice (nīti) / realised justice (nyāya) FACT:
- capability approach FACT:
- public reasoning FACT:
- social justice FACT:
- fraternity FACT:

7.2 Ready-to-use statements

1. **Equality is best read as equal moral standing, not numerical sameness.** ANALYSIS: 2. **Formal equality without fair background conditions may stabilise privilege rather than remove it.** ANALYSIS: 3. **For Berlin, the central question is not whether self-mastery matters, but whether it can be politicised into coercion.** ANALYSIS: 4. **Mill's harm principle gives liberty a moral presumption while still permitting regulation of injury to others.** FACT: 5. **Rousseau's distinction between natural and moral inequality exposes the social manufacture of domination.** FACT: 6. **Rawls does not abolish inequality; he civilises it by subjecting it to liberty, opportunity, and the difference principle.** ANALYSIS: 7. **Nozick asks how holdings arose, not whether they fit a preferred distributive pattern.** FACT: 8. **Sen reorients justice from perfect institutions to comparative reduction of manifest injustice.** FACT: 9. **Ambedkar reminds us that political equality is fragile where social hierarchy denies fraternity.** ANALYSIS: 10. **Liberty and equality remain normatively incomplete unless justice decides their scope and priority.** ANALYSIS:

Corpus-Driven Depth Delta

- ANALYSIS: **Priority:** Primary ownership is 14 of 112 socio-political parts across 2018-2025.
- FACT: **Required doctrinal depth:** The full corpus requires liberty/equality as democratic features, Rawls-Plato continuity, Nozick, Rousseau, Sen-Rawls, Marxian equity/equality and the justice-mediated relation among all three ideals.
- WRONG: **Trap / answer consequence:** Do not duplicate democracy questions owned by Forms of Government or Marxism questions owned by Political Ideologies; route by the demanded normative concept.

PYQ Routing Table (2018-2025)

ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal:** 14 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper II corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2018	Q2(a)	20	How far can liberty and equality be considered as distinctive features of democracy ? Discuss.
2019	Q1(a)	10	How far do you think John Rawls is continuing with Plato's concept of justice?
2019	Q4(b)	15	Does liberty put limitations to equality? Discuss.
2020	Q1(a)	10	Is the concept of liberty realizable in the modern technological society? Explain.
2021	Q1(a)	10	Discuss critically the distributive theory of justice as propounded by R. Nozick.
2021	Q1(b)	10	How does Rousseau distinguish between natural and artificial inequality ? Explain.
2021	Q2(a)	20	Discuss whether Amartya Sen's idea of justice is an improvement upon Rawl's theory of justice.
2022	Q1(d)	10	"Complete liberty may lead to inequality while order and restrictions imply a necessary loss of freedom." Critically discuss.
2022	Q2(c)	15	Explain the difference between the notion of equity and equality with reference to Marxian philosophy.
2023	Q1(a)	10	What is meant by justice as fairness? Explain Rawls' theory of justice.
2024	Q1(a)	10	Briefly discuss Plato's concept of justice.
2024	Q2(b)	15	Critically evaluate the concepts of liberty and equality as political ideals.
2025	Q1(e)	10	Discuss the salient features of equality according to J.S. Mill.
2025	Q4(a)	20	How are both equality and liberty inadequate as social and political ideals without justice? Discuss.

See the Socio-Political PYQ Bank, 2018-2025.

Answer Architecture (10 / 15 / 20 Marks)

9.0 Directive decoder - read the verb before the topic

Directive in the stem	What is actually being scored	Minimum structural obligation	Failure mode that costs marks
Discuss	controlled exposition plus at least one live tension	doctrine -> distinction -> one objection -> verdict	listing views without adjudicating
Explain	internal logic, not evaluation	statement -> premises -> key distinction -> example	inserting criticism the stem did not ask for, at the cost of exposition
Critically discuss / evaluate	the objection-reply layer is the answer	doctrine -> strongest objection -> best reply -> residual problem -> graded verdict	one-sided demolition, or praise with a token "however"
How far / to what extent	a <i>degree</i> judgment is compulsory	specify the conditions under which the claim holds and fails	answering yes/no, or refusing to commit
Compare / distinguish	shared axes, not two mini-essays	fix 3-4 axes, run both thinkers down each, then adjudicate	sequential biography of two thinkers
Is X an improvement upon Y?	criterion of improvement must be named first	state the test -> apply -> concede what Y still does better	asserting improvement without a standard

9.1 10-mark method (~150 words · 4 moves · ~12 minutes)

- Exact doctrine (2 lines).** Define in the thinker's own technical vocabulary - *proportional equality, harm principle, natural vs artificial inequality, entitlement, non-domination*.
- Argument spine (4-5 lines).** Numbered premises, not adjectives. One distinction that only someone who has read the doctrine could make.
- One evidence unit (2 lines)** from §9.4, plus its limitation.
- Graded verdict (2 lines)** from §9.5. Never a summary; always an adjudication.

WRONG: At 10 marks do not attempt two thinkers, two objections, or an Indian illustration unless the stem asks for one. Depth of one doctrine beats breadth.

9.2 15-mark method (~220 words · 6 moves · ~18 minutes)

- Frame the axis of dispute** - not the topic. ("The question is whether liberty is measured by interference or by dependence.")
- Side A in its strongest form**, with its presupposition stated.
- Side B in its strongest form**, with the presupposition it denies.
- Objection -> reply pair** (one only, fully worked; two half-worked pairs score lower).
- Two evidence units** from §9.4, drawn from different families.
- Conditional verdict**: name the conditions under which each side wins.

ANALYSIS: For "compare/distinguish" stems, insert one 3-axis table here. For "how far" stems, the conditional verdict is the mark-bearing move and must be at least three lines.

9.3 20-mark method (~300 words · 8 moves · ~25 minutes)

- Provisional thesis** in one sentence, using the stem's own directive verb.
- Concept map**: define all ideals or both thinkers in play; state the criterion of assessment.
- Strongest case for the proposition**, reconstructed as premises.
- Strongest rival**, given its best formulation - not a straw position.
- Two objection -> reply chains**, each ending in a *residual* problem that survives the reply.
- Comparative adjudication** on scope, presupposition and institutional reach.
- One dated Indian illustration**, classified accurately as constitutional provision, statute or judgment, with the caution that legal status is not philosophical proof.
- Graded verdict** that concedes something to the losing side.

ANALYSIS: On composite stems ("liberty and equality inadequate without justice"), the mark-bearing move is showing *why* the third ideal is needed - that liberty and equality are each indeterminate about **which** liberties and **which** equalities, and that justice supplies the ordering criterion. State this explicitly.

9.4 Selectable evidence bank - pick 1 at 10 marks, 2 at 15, 4-5 at 20

Each unit is **Claim -> Named anchor -> Use for -> Limitation**. Select by the stem's demand; do not deploy the whole bank.

- **E1 · Inequality is historical, not natural.** Claim: most inequality is artificial/moral, arising with property and comparison -> Named: Rousseau's natural vs artificial inequality -> Use for: 2021 Q1(b); any "origin of inequality" stem -> Limit: a genetic account of inequality is not by itself a justification of any remedy.
- **E2 · Equality is not sameness of share.** Claim: proportional equality distributes by relevant criterion; arithmetic equality restores balance -> Named: Aristotle's distributive vs corrective justice (§3.3) -> Use for: any "equality" or "justice" stem needing a first distinction -> Limit: leaves the relevant criterion unspecified (§3.3A).
- **E3 · The criterion problem.** Claim: need, desert, merit, contribution, equal share and compensation each govern a different sphere -> Named: the criteria grid (§3.3A) -> Use for: "equity vs equality", social-justice and reservation-adjacent stems -> Limit: sphere boundaries are themselves contested.
- **E4 · Liberty has two poles.** Claim: freedom from interference vs freedom to realise a rational self -> Named: Berlin's negative/positive distinction; Green's enabling freedom -> Use for: 2020 Q1(a), 2022 Q1(d), 2024 Q2(b) -> Limit: Berlin's own warning that the positive pole can be turned into coercion in the name of the "real self".
- **E5 · Liberty as status, not as event-count.** Claim: an un-interfered-with dependent is still unfree -> Named: Pettit's non-domination (1997), with Skinner's historical recovery (1998) (§2.8) -> Use for: dissolving the liberty-equality trade-off; the highest-value depth marker on liberty stems -> Limit: "arbitrary" remains partly indeterminate; outside the classic Berlin framing, so flag it as a third family.
- **E6 · Self-regarding vs other-regarding.** Claim: society may coerce only to prevent harm to others -> Named: Mill's harm principle -> Use for: 2025 Q1(e); liberty-limits stems -> Limit: the boundary of "harm" and the exclusion of the "backward" from the principle's scope.
- **E7 · Justice as fairness.** Claim: principles chosen behind a veil of ignorance yield equal basic liberties, fair equality of opportunity and the difference principle -> Named: Rawls -> Use for: 2019 Q1(a), 2023 Q1(a) -> Limit: institutional focus can neglect actual realised freedom (E9) and the family (route to Gender owner).
- **E8 · Entitlement, not pattern.** Claim: justice is historical - acquisition, transfer, rectification - so any patterned end-state requires continuous interference -> Named: Nozick -> Use for: 2021 Q1(a) -> Limit: the acquisition and rectification principles are the weakest links, since both need an independent criterion.
- **E9 · Realisation, not only institutional design.** Claim: comparative assessment of actual lives beats the search for perfectly just institutions -> Named: Sen, *The Idea of Justice* -> Use for: 2021 Q2(a) -> Limit: comparative ranking without an ideal benchmark can under-determine choice among rival improvements.
- **E10 · Equity as need-sensitivity.** Claim: "to each according to need" supersedes equal shares only at a later stage; distribution under scarcity still reflects contribution -> Named: Marx's *Critique of the Gotha Programme* formula -> Use for: 2022 Q2(c) -> Limit: the two-stage structure is a normative projection, not a demonstrated historical law.
- **E11 · Political liberty and social democracy.** Claim: political equality without social and economic equality is a contradiction that a polity cannot sustain indefinitely -> Named: Ambedkar (§3.8) -> Use for: any stem joining democracy to equality -> Limit: this is the Indian normative anchor; the constitutional detail is owned by the Caste file.
- **E12 · The compensatory principle.** Claim: corrective justice, generalised from transactions to structures, requires positive remedy for transmitted disadvantage -> Named: §3.3B -> Use for: social-justice stems -> Limit: terminus and over-inclusion problems; the affirmative-action debate itself belongs to the Caste owner.

9.5 Graded verdict formulas (adapt; do not reproduce mechanically)

- **Conditional verdict:** "The claim holds where <condition>, and fails where <condition>; the stem is therefore best answered as a matter of degree rather than of kind."
- **Asymmetric verdict:** "<Thinker A>'s diagnosis survives; the remedy does not."
- **Improvement verdict:** "Judged by <named criterion>, <A> improves on ; judged by <rival criterion>, retains the advantage - so 'improvement' is criterion-relative and must be stated as such."

- **Ordering verdict:** "Liberty and equality are indispensable but each is indeterminate about which liberties and which equalities matter; justice is the criterion that orders their competing claims."
- **Reconstruction verdict:** "The objection defeats the doctrine's strong form but leaves its reconstructed form standing under <named constraint>."

Link-Outs to Related Topics

- Sovereignty
- Individual and State
- Political obligation: see Individual and State.
- Religion and Morality
- Kant
- PYQ Bank: Socio-Political 2018-2025
- Master Framework

Sources

- O. P. Gauba, *An Introduction to Political Theory*, searchable local PDF pp. 367-412 and 432-453.
- *Socio-Political Philosophy*, searchable local PDF pp. 7-11, 25-40 and 47-54.
- Robert Audi (ed.), *The Cambridge Dictionary of Philosophy*, searchable local PDF pp. 489-490 and 536.
- Rajeev Bhargava and Ashok Acharya, *Political Theory: An Introduction*.
- John Rawls, *A Theory of Justice*.
- Robert Nozick, *Anarchy, State and Utopia*.
- Amartya Sen, *The Idea of Justice*.
- Isaiah Berlin, *Two Concepts of Liberty*.
- J. S. Mill, *On Liberty*.
- J. S. Mill, *The Subjection of Women*.
- Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics* Book V and *Politics* - distributive and corrective justice, proportional equality.
- Philip Pettit, *Republicanism: A Theory of Freedom and Government* (1997) - freedom as non-domination; cited by title and year only, paraphrased and never quoted.
- Quentin Skinner, *Liberty before Liberalism* (1998) - historical recovery of the republican conception; cited by title and year only.
- Karl Marx, *Critique of the Gotha Programme* - the need-based distributive formula used in §3.3A and E10.
- The Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act, 1976 - India Code, used only as a dated statutory illustration of a non-domination remedy, not as evidence that domination has ended.
- The Constitution of India - Legislative Department, Articles 14-16, used as dated constitutional illustration only.

ANALYSIS: Provenance note for §2.8, §3.3A and §3.3B (added in this pass): the republican non-domination module, the distributive-criteria grid and the compensatory-principle reconstruction are named-scholar syntheses adapted into this Philosophy owner. They carry no page, chapter, edition or verbatim wording for Pettit, Skinner, Rawls, Nozick or Aristotle, and no empirical claim about any Indian government, party or period. The affirmative-action policy debate is deliberately **not** developed here; it is owned by the Caste file.

ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - EXACTLY 48 QUESTIONS

Questions 1-40 are core coverage - four per subtopic across the ten subtopics; Questions 41-48 are remedial items targeting the most common misreadings. Correct answers rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D 12 times.

MCQ 1

The thesis that liberty and equality are 'indeterminate until justice orders them' means that:

- A. each ideal is silent about which of its own variants (which liberties, which equality) should prevail B. liberty and equality are meaningless concepts C. justice is the only genuine political value D. equality must always defeat liberty

Answer: A. each ideal is silent about which of its own variants (which liberties, which equality) should prevail

Explanation: Liberty does not by itself say which liberties are basic, and equality does not say which equality (of status, resource, welfare or capability) matters; justice supplies the ordering criteria.

MCQ 2

Justice is called the 'architectonic' ideal of the triad because it:

- A. is chronologically the oldest of the three ideals B. supplies the ordering criteria that rank and reconcile liberty and equality C. abolishes the need for liberty and equality D. is guaranteed only by written constitutions

Answer: B. supplies the ordering criteria that rank and reconcile liberty and equality

Explanation: Architectonic = ordering: justice provides the criteria (desert, fairness, need, entitlement, capability) that decide the scope and priority of the other two ideals.

MCQ 3

'Directive-sensitivity' in answering these questions means:

- A. always agreeing with the statement quoted in the question B. writing the longest possible answer C. tailoring the answer's structure to the command word (discuss / critically evaluate / how far) D. citing as many thinkers as possible regardless of relevance

Answer: C. tailoring the answer's structure to the command word (discuss / critically evaluate / how far)

Explanation: The directive fixes the required structure: 'discuss' exposes a tension, 'critically evaluate' demands objection-reply, 'how far' demands a degree judgment.

MCQ 4

The safest general verdict pattern across liberty-equality-justice stems is that the ideals are:

- A. such that liberty always trumps equality B. such that equality always trumps liberty C. never in conflict with one another D. complementary at the base and rivalrous only beyond a threshold, ordered by justice

Answer: D. complementary at the base and rivalrous only beyond a threshold, ordered by justice

Explanation: Equal basic liberties are themselves an equality; conflict appears only past a threshold, where justice adjudicates. Flat 'always' claims lose the degree marks.

MCQ 5

The foundational premise of equality as a political ideal is:

- A. the equal moral worth of persons, whatever their birth or status B. that all people are identical in ability C. that all incomes must be exactly equal D. that relevant differences should never be recognised

Answer: A. the equal moral worth of persons, whatever their birth or status Explanation: Equality begins from equal moral worth / equal consideration, not from a false claim of identical capacities or mandated identical incomes.

MCQ 6

'Formal / legal equality' refers to:

- A. equal economic outcomes for all B. equal treatment before the law and equal application of rules C. proportional representation in the legislature D. equality of natural talents

Answer: B. equal treatment before the law and equal application of rules Explanation: Formal/legal equality is equality before and under the law; it is necessary but, taken alone, compatible with deep social and economic disadvantage.

MCQ 7

Equality of opportunity differs from equality of outcome in that opportunity-equality:

- A. guarantees identical final results for everyone B. is simply another name for formal legal equality C. equalises starting conditions and access rather than final shares D. is rejected by every liberal thinker

Answer: C. equalises starting conditions and access rather than final shares Explanation: Opportunity equality targets fair access and starting conditions; outcome equality targets final distributions. Fair equality of opportunity is a central liberal-egalitarian demand.

MCQ 8

The reminder that 'equality is not sameness' means that:

- A. equality requires abolishing every human difference B. equality and identity are exact synonyms C. equal treatment always requires literally identical treatment D. treating people as equals can require differentiated treatment responsive to relevant differences

Answer: D. treating people as equals can require differentiated treatment responsive to relevant differences Explanation: Treating people AS equals (equal concern and respect) sometimes requires unequal treatment - e.g. accommodating disability or disadvantage - so equality is not mechanical sameness.

MCQ 9

Rousseau's distinction between natural and moral/political inequality holds that:

- A. the most oppressive inequalities are conventionally produced, not natural B. all inequality is rooted in biology C. natural inequality is the only real inequality D. inequality does not exist in civil society at all

Answer: A. the most oppressive inequalities are conventionally produced, not natural Explanation: Natural inequality (strength, age, health) becomes politically toxic only when institutions - property, status - convert it into durable domination.

MCQ 10

For J.S. Mill, equality is compatible with:

- A. the suppression of individuality B. individuality and free self-development C. legally enforced identical lifestyles D. the permanent subjection of women

Answer: B. individuality and free self-development Explanation: Mill's egalitarianism prizes free self-development and expressly rejects the subjection of women; equality secures the conditions for individuality, not its suppression.

MCQ 11

Marx's claim that 'equal right is a right of inequality' is aimed at:

- A. the equality of women B. the political equality of votes C. abstract, formally equal exchange that ignores unequal needs and class position D. Rawls's difference principle

Answer: C. abstract, formally equal exchange that ignores unequal needs and class position Explanation: A single common measure applied to unequally-placed people reproduces disadvantage; Marx exposes the class content beneath formally equal exchange.

MCQ 12

On a disciplined reading, the Marxian principle 'to each according to his need' is:

- A. an immediate market wage rule B. identical to equality of opportunity C. a demand for equal incomes right now D. a principle for a higher stage of cooperation, not a present salary formula

Answer: D. a principle for a higher stage of cooperation, not a present salary formula Explanation: Reading the need-principle as a present pay rule invites the 'vague / weakens incentive' objection; Marx locates it at a transformed, higher stage of production.

MCQ 13

Amartya Sen's answer to 'equality of what?' foregrounds:

A. capabilities - the real freedom to achieve valued functionings B. equality of subjective welfare only C. equality of primary goods only D. strict equality of money income

Answer: A. capabilities - the real freedom to achieve valued functionings Explanation: Sen shifts the metric from resources/welfare to capabilities: the effective freedom to be and do what one has reason to value.

MCQ 14

Sen's critique of resourcism (e.g. Rawlsian primary goods) is that:

A. resources are wholly irrelevant to justice B. equal resources yield unequal real freedom because people differ in conversion C. capabilities can never be compared D. income is the only measure that matters

Answer: B. equal resources yield unequal real freedom because people differ in conversion Explanation: People convert resources into functionings at different rates (disability, metabolism, social role), so equal primary goods can still leave unequal real freedom.

MCQ 15

Dworkin's 'equality of resources' is distinctive for being:

A. indifferent to personal responsibility B. a direct equalisation of welfare C. ambition-sensitive but endowment-insensitive - holding people responsible for choices, not brute luck D. a rejection of all markets and prices

Answer: C. ambition-sensitive but endowment-insensitive - holding people responsible for choices, not brute luck Explanation: Dworkin's scheme (hypothetical auction and insurance) lets outcomes track chosen ambitions while neutralising unchosen brute-luck disadvantages in endowment.

MCQ 16

The shared upshot of the 'equality of what?' debate is that:

A. equality is a single, self-evident quantity B. only money-income equality matters C. the metric of equality is ultimately irrelevant D. specifying the metric (welfare / resources / capability) is unavoidable and shapes the institutions required

Answer: D. specifying the metric (welfare / resources / capability) is unavoidable and shapes the institutions required Explanation: There is no metric-free equality: choosing welfare, resources or capability changes both the diagnosis of injustice and the remedies demanded.

MCQ 17

Berlin's NEGATIVE liberty is:

- A. the absence of deliberate interference by others within one's area of action B. self-mastery achieved through rational autonomy C. participation in collective self-rule D. freedom understood as non-domination

Answer: A. the absence of deliberate interference by others within one's area of action Explanation: Negative liberty answers 'how many doors are open?' - the extent of the area within which one is left un-interfered with.

MCQ 18

Berlin warned that POSITIVE liberty can be perverted when:

- A. it is defined merely as non-interference B. a 'higher self' is invoked to coerce people 'for their own good' C. it is applied only to economic life D. it is limited by Mill's harm principle

Answer: B. a 'higher self' is invoked to coerce people 'for their own good' Explanation: The danger is the split-self move: identifying a 'real' self whose freedom justifies coercing the actual person - the pathway from self-mastery to authoritarian control.

MCQ 19

Mill's harm principle holds that power may be exercised over an individual against their will only to:

- A. improve their moral character B. enforce the majority's morality C. prevent harm to others D. maximise their own happiness

Answer: C. prevent harm to others Explanation: The sole legitimate ground for coercion is preventing harm to others; purely self-regarding conduct lies outside rightful interference.

MCQ 20

A common misreading of Mill's On Liberty treats it as:

- A. a defence of free discussion B. a limit on paternalism C. a defence of individuality D. an endorsement of unlimited licence with no regard for others

Answer: D. an endorsement of unlimited licence with no regard for others Explanation: Mill defends liberty of self-regarding action and discussion, not licence: the harm principle itself sets the boundary against injury to others.

MCQ 21

For Locke, liberty is best described as:

- A. freedom under known, settled law that protects natural rights - licence is not liberty B. freedom wherever the law happens to be silent C. obedience to the general will D. the positive power to flourish

Answer: A. freedom under known, settled law that protects natural rights - licence is not liberty Explanation: Locke ties liberty to life under settled, rights-protecting law and sharply distinguishes liberty from licence.

MCQ 22

Rousseau's phrase that a citizen may be 'forced to be free' is examiner-bait because it:

- A. clearly endorses anarchism B. can be read as legitimate collective self-rule OR as a licence for coercion C. openly rejects the general will D. denies that any law can bind

Answer: B. can be read as legitimate collective self-rule OR as a licence for coercion Explanation: Both readings are textually available - co-authored law vs majoritarian coercion - which is exactly why it must be handled with a balanced verdict.

MCQ 23

T.H. Green's contribution to the concept of liberty is:

- A. reducing liberty to bare non-interference B. equating liberty with security C. positive / enabling freedom - the power to do worthwhile things D. denying that education has any bearing on freedom

Answer: C. positive / enabling freedom - the power to do worthwhile things Explanation: Green's freedom is enabling: non-interference is hollow for someone disabled by ignorance or destitution, so institutions should widen worthwhile options.

MCQ 24

The best statement of the liberty-equality relation is that they:

- A. are permanent, level-independent enemies B. are always exactly identical C. require equality to be sacrificed to liberty in every case D. reinforce at the level of basic liberties and conflict mainly beyond a threshold

Answer: D. reinforce at the level of basic liberties and conflict mainly beyond a threshold Explanation: Equal basic liberties are themselves an equality; the clash is a matter of degree that appears only when demands rise above a threshold.

MCQ 25

Republican freedom as non-domination is the absence of:

- A. another's capacity for arbitrary interference, whether exercised or not B. all law and government C. any inequality of wealth whatsoever D. positive self-mastery

Answer: A. another's capacity for arbitrary interference, whether exercised or not Explanation: Domination is a standing capacity to interfere arbitrarily; one is unfree when subject to it even if the power is never actually used.

MCQ 26

The 'un-interfered-with slave' example shows that:

- A. interference and domination are identical B. one can be dominated (and so unfree) even without any actual interference C. domination requires physical force D. non-interference always guarantees freedom

Answer: B. one can be dominated (and so unfree) even without any actual interference Explanation: A slave with an indulgent master suffers no interference yet must defer and self-censor - real unfreedom an interference-count cannot detect.

MCQ 27

On the republican view, non-arbitrary law is:

- A. always a pure subtraction from liberty B. wholly irrelevant to freedom C. freedom-constituting, because it strips others of arbitrary power D. identical to domination

Answer: C. freedom-constituting, because it strips others of arbitrary power Explanation: Where the negative view sees every law as a cost to liberty, republicanism sees non-arbitrary, contestable law as constitutive of freedom.

MCQ 28

The correct provenance discipline for the non-domination module is to:

- A. quote Pettit's page numbers freely B. treat Skinner as the normative theorist C. attribute the historical recovery to Pettit D. cite Pettit (1997) for theory and Skinner (1998) for history, by title and year, without quotation

Answer: D. cite Pettit (1997) for theory and Skinner (1998) for history, by title and year, without quotation Explanation: Pettit supplies the normative theory and Skinner the historical recovery; cite by title and year only, with no quoted text or page detail.

MCQ 29

Plato's concept of justice is:

- A. harmony - each part of soul and city performing its own proper function B. the equal distribution of income C. the will of the stronger D. the maximisation of aggregate utility

Answer: A. harmony - each part of soul and city performing its own proper function Explanation: For Plato justice is right-order: reason ruling the soul and each class doing its own work in the city, not external distribution.

MCQ 30

Aristotle's DISTRIBUTIVE justice requires:

- A. arithmetic equality for all regardless of merit B. proportional shares that track relevant merit C. the rectification of transactional wrongs D. the abolition of private property

Answer: B. proportional shares that track relevant merit Explanation: Distributive justice allocates goods in proportion to relevant desert or merit - proportional, not arithmetic, equality.

MCQ 31

Aristotle's CORRECTIVE justice is characterised by:

- A. proportional distribution by desert B. harmony of the parts of the soul C. arithmetic restoration of a balance disturbed by a wrong D. the maximisation of capability

Answer: C. arithmetic restoration of a balance disturbed by a wrong Explanation: Corrective justice restores the prior balance between two parties after a transaction or wrong, treating them as arithmetically equal.

MCQ 32

The 'criteria problem' in the theory of justice is:

- A. deciding whether justice exists at all B. proving that Plato was correct C. abolishing all distributive criteria D. identifying which criterion (need / desert / merit / contribution / equal share / compensation) governs which sphere

Answer: D. identifying which criterion (need / desert / merit / contribution / equal share / compensation) governs which sphere Explanation: Injustice often consists in exporting a criterion out of its proper sphere (e.g. wealth buying political power); the task is to match criterion to good.

MCQ 33

In Rawls's theory the lexically FIRST principle is:

- A. equal basic liberties for all B. the difference principle C. fair equality of opportunity D. the maximisation of average utility

Answer: A. equal basic liberties for all Explanation: Equal basic liberty is lexically prior and is never traded for economic gain; it is therefore false to say Rawls's first principle is equality.

MCQ 34

Nozick's entitlement theory of justice is:

- A. a patterned principle of distribution B. a historical theory: justice depends on just acquisition, transfer and rectification C. a defence of the difference principle D. a capability metric

Answer: B. a historical theory: justice depends on just acquisition, transfer and rectification Explanation: For Nozick a distribution is just if it arose by just steps, whatever its shape; the Wilt Chamberlain case shows patterns require constant interference with free transfers.

MCQ 35

Sen's distinction between niti and nyaya emphasises:

- A. rules to the exclusion of outcomes
- B. purely transcendental institutional design
- C. justice realised in actual lives, not merely correct institutions
- D. the abolition of public reasoning

Answer: C. justice realised in actual lives, not merely correct institutions Explanation: Niti is the correctness of rules/institutions; nyaya is justice as it is realised in people's lives - Sen prioritises comparative removal of manifest injustice.

MCQ 36

Ambedkar's political philosophy insists that political democracy is unstable without:

- A. a minimal, night-watchman state
- B. the veil of ignorance
- C. the entitlement theory of holdings
- D. social democracy grounded in liberty, equality and fraternity

Answer: D. social democracy grounded in liberty, equality and fraternity Explanation: For Ambedkar formal political equality is hollow while social hierarchy (caste) persists; fraternity and social democracy underwrite political democracy.

MCQ 37

A high-scoring 'compare Rawls and Nozick' answer should:

- A. fix shared axes and adjudicate, rather than write two separate biographies
- B. narrate each thinker's life story in turn
- C. avoid reaching any verdict
- D. consist mainly of long quotations from both

Answer: A. fix shared axes and adjudicate, rather than write two separate biographies Explanation: Comparison marks reward shared axes (starting point, unit of concern, role of the state) run down for both thinkers, followed by a reasoned adjudication.

MCQ 38

Which is a genuine 'trap' the canonical file warns against?

- A. distinguishing negative from positive liberty
- B. saying Rawls's first principle is equality rather than liberty
- C. citing Ambedkar philosophically
- D. giving a graded, balanced verdict

Answer: B. saying Rawls's first principle is equality rather than liberty Explanation: Rawls's first principle is equal LIBERTY; misstating it as equality is a classic error the traps section flags.

MCQ 39

The directive 'critically evaluate' primarily rewards:

- A. one-sided advocacy for a favoured thinker B. a bare list of definitions C. an objection-and-reply structure closing with a graded verdict D. the longest possible introduction

Answer: C. an objection-and-reply structure closing with a graded verdict Explanation: 'Critically evaluate' scores the objection-reply layer and a verdict that concedes something to the losing side, not one-sided praise or demolition.

MCQ 40

Which statement correctly distinguishes procedural from substantive justice?

- A. A consistent procedure guarantees a just principle and outcome B. Substantive justice makes hearing and impartiality unnecessary C. The two expressions are always exact synonyms D. Fair procedure is necessary, but unjust starting conditions or principles still require substantive scrutiny

Answer: D. fair procedure is necessary, but unjust starting conditions or principles still require substantive scrutiny Explanation: Procedural justice evaluates how a decision is produced; substantive justice evaluates the governing principle, distribution and status relation. Neither can safely replace the other.

Remedial MCQ 41

REMEDIAL (corrects 'Rawls makes equality his first principle'): the accurate statement is that:

- A. Rawls's first principle is equal LIBERTY, lexically prior to the difference principle B. Rawls has no priority rules among principles C. Rawls rejects basic liberties D. Rawls simply maximises aggregate welfare

Answer: A. Rawls's first principle is equal LIBERTY, lexically prior to the difference principle Explanation: The equal-basic-liberties principle is lexically first; economic principles (fair opportunity, difference principle) are subordinate to it.

Remedial MCQ 42

REMEDIAL (corrects 'Berlin rejects positive liberty'): in fact Berlin:

- A. equates the two liberties as one concept B. distinguishes (does not reject) positive liberty, warning only against its abuse C. denies that negative liberty exists D. defends positive liberty exclusively

Answer: B. distinguishes (does not reject) positive liberty, warning only against its abuse Explanation: Berlin analyses both concepts; his target is the perversion of positive liberty via a coercive 'higher self', not positive liberty as such.

Remedial MCQ 43

REMEDIAL (corrects 'equity and equality are the same'): correctly stated:

- A. equity means identical shares for everyone B. equality means need-adjusted shares C. equality applies a common measure, whereas equity differentiates by need D. neither concept has anything to do with distribution

Answer: C. equality applies a common measure, whereas equity differentiates by need Explanation: Equality = one measure for all; equity = differentiated response to unequal need. Treating unequally-placed people identically can be inequitable.

Remedial MCQ 44

REMEDIAL (corrects 'Nozick defends a patterned distribution'): in fact Nozick:

- A. endorses the difference principle B. requires an end-state of equality C. is a welfare egalitarian D. is historical / entitlement-based and rejects fixed patterns (Wilt Chamberlain)

Answer: D. is historical / entitlement-based and rejects fixed patterns (Wilt Chamberlain) Explanation: Nozick's justice-in-holdings judges the PROCESS (acquisition, transfer, rectification), not the shape; maintaining a pattern would violate free transfer.

Remedial MCQ 45

REMEDIAL (corrects 'Mill's harm principle allows coercion for a person's own good'): correctly stated, the harm principle:

A. restricts coercion to preventing harm to OTHERS, not self-regarding conduct B. authorises censorship of unpopular opinion C. requires the suppression of individuality D. permits coercion to enforce the majority's tastes

Answer: A. restricts coercion to preventing harm to OTHERS, not self-regarding conduct Explanation: Self-regarding conduct is protected; only conduct that harms others is a legitimate ground for interference - the opposite of paternalism.

Remedial MCQ 46

REMEDIAL (corrects 'non-interference guarantees freedom'): the republican correction is that:

A. interference and domination are identical B. a dependent who is not currently interfered with may still be dominated and unfree C. law can never constitute freedom D. domination requires actual physical force

Answer: B. a dependent who is not currently interfered with may still be dominated and unfree Explanation: Freedom is absence of DOMINATION (arbitrary power), not merely absence of interference; the un-interfered-with dependent is still unfree.

Remedial MCQ 47

REMEDIAL (corrects 'Sen's capability approach is mere welfare economics'): correctly stated, Sen's account:

A. equates capability with money income B. abandons freedom as a central value C. is political-philosophical - capabilities as freedom, refined through public reasoning D. rejects any comparison of social states

Answer: C. is political-philosophical - capabilities as freedom, refined through public reasoning Explanation: Sen's capabilities are about real freedom and are shaped by public reasoning and comparative assessment - not a narrow welfarist metric.

Remedial MCQ 48

REMEDIAL (corrects 'justice as fairness means identical shares for all'): correctly stated, Rawls holds that:

A. all inequality whatsoever is banned B. the difference principle forbids every inequality C. fairness requires strictly equal outcomes D. inequalities are permitted if they meet fair equality of opportunity and benefit the least advantaged

Answer: D. inequalities are permitted if they meet fair equality of opportunity and benefit the least advantaged Explanation: Justice as fairness tolerates inequalities that satisfy fair equality of opportunity and improve the position of the least advantaged - not equal outcomes.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

EXAM APPLICATION 1 - The Ideals Triad: Map, Working Thesis and the Ordering Problem

This subtopic is the frame for every COMPOSITE stem that names two or three ideals at once.

- 2018 Q2(a), 20 marks -- liberty and equality as distinctive features of democracy -> open with the triad, then show justice ordering them.
- 2024 Q2(b), 15 marks -- liberty and equality as political ideals -> the conflict/complement axis is the answer.
- 2025 Q4(a), 20 marks -- equality and liberty inadequate WITHOUT justice -> the mark-bearing move is to prove each is indeterminate until justice supplies the ordering criterion.

MEMORY: Composite spine -> name the two ideals -> show each is indeterminate alone -> bring in justice as the ordering criterion -> graded verdict that concedes something to the losing side.

EXAM APPLICATION 2 - Equality I: Equal Worth, the Four Forms, Opportunity vs Outcome

This subtopic supplies the FIRST DISTINCTION for almost every equality stem.

- 2024 Q2(b), 15 marks -- liberty and equality as political ideals -> lead with the four forms so "equality" is specified, not vague.
- 2022 Q1(d), 10 marks -- "complete liberty may lead to inequality" -> the formal-vs-substantive gap is the pivot.
- 2025 Q4(a), 20 marks -- inadequate without justice -> show equality is under-specified (of what? status, opportunity, outcome?) until justice chooses.

MEMORY: Equality spine -> equal worth (not sameness) -> name the relevant form (legal / political / social / economic) -> opportunity vs outcome -> which criterion, and why, is the mark-bearing move.

EXAM APPLICATION 3 - Equality II: Rousseau, Mill and Marx on Inequality, Individuality and Need

Three exact owners live in this subtopic.

- 2021 Q1(b), 10 marks -- Rousseau on natural vs artificial inequality -> this is the whole answer; state the distinction and its diagnostic force.
- 2025 Q1(e), 10 marks -- salient features of equality according to J.S. Mill -> list Mill's features (equal worth, legal/civic equality, women's equality, compatible with individuality, hostility to custom-hierarchy, qualified economic concern).
- 2022 Q2(c), 15 marks -- equity vs equality in Marxian philosophy -> the equality/equity table is the spine. Routing note: this part is OWNED here (the demanded concept is equity vs equality); Marxism-as-ideology stems belong to Political Ideologies.

MEMORY: Do not import the Marx-as-ideology answer here; the demand is the equity/equality DISTINCTION, framed by Marx.

EXAM APPLICATION 4 - Equality III: 'Equality of What?' -- Sen, Cohen and Dworkin

This subtopic is depth-ammunition for equality and justice stems alike.

- 2021 Q2(a), 20 marks -- Sen vs Rawls -> the capability metric and public reasoning are the improvement claim (developed fully in Justice II).
- 2024 Q2(b), 15 marks / 2025 Q4(a), 20 marks -- when the stem says "equality", raise the metric question: equality of WHAT?

MEMORY: If a stem treats equality as one flat thing, win marks by asking "equality of what -- welfare, resources or capabilities?" and naming Sen.

EXAM APPLICATION 5 - Liberty I: Meaning, Berlin's Two Concepts, Mill's Harm Principle

Berlin and Mill are the two highest-yield names on any liberty stem.

- 2020 Q1(a), 10 marks -- liberty in technological society -> Berlin's negative pole plus the surveillance worry (developed in Liberty III).
- 2022 Q1(d), 10 marks -- "complete liberty may lead to inequality" -> Mill's harm principle sets the limit of self-regarding freedom.
- 2024 Q2(b), 15 marks -- liberty and equality as political ideals -> Berlin's pair fixes WHICH liberty is meant.

MEMORY: 10-mark liberty spine -> negative/positive distinction -> Berlin's warning OR Mill's harm gate -> one evidence unit -> graded verdict.

EXAM APPLICATION 6 - Liberty II: Hobbes, Locke, Rousseau, Green and the Liberty-Equality Relation

This is the HOME subtopic for the recurring liberty-equality parts.

- 2018 Q2(a), 20 marks -- liberty and equality as distinctive features of democracy -> run the conflict/complement table, then justice as arbiter.
- 2019 Q4(b), 15 marks -- does liberty put limitations to equality -> a "how far" stem; the conditional verdict is the mark-bearing move.
- 2022 Q1(d), 10 marks -- complete liberty -> inequality, order -> loss of freedom -> both halves are true only past the threshold.
- 2024 Q2(b), 15 marks -- liberty and equality as political ideals -> critical evaluation of both.

MEMORY: "How far" = degree judgment compulsory. Name the conditions under which liberty limits equality and the conditions under which they reinforce.

EXAM APPLICATION 7 - Liberty III: Technological Society and Republican Non-Domination

- 2020 Q1(a), 10 marks -- is liberty realizable in modern technological society
-> yes, but only under vigilance against surveillance and informational power; convenience is not autonomy.
- 2019 Q4(b) / 2022 Q1(d) / 2024 Q2(b) -- non-domination DISSOLVES the liberty-equality trade-off: material dependence IS domination, so some equalising measures INCREASE freedom rather than trading against it. This is the single highest-value depth marker on liberty stems.

MEMORY: On any liberty-vs-equality stem, deploy non-domination to show that certain equalisations are freedom-INCREASING, not freedom-reducing.

EXAM APPLICATION 8 - Justice I: Meaning, Plato, Aristotle, the Criteria Problem and Corrective Justice

- 2024 Q1(a), 10 marks -- Plato's concept of justice -> harmony/function in soul and city; note it is not democratic equality but role-fitting order.
- 2022 Q2(c) (equity/equality) and any social-justice stem -> the criteria grid (need/desert/merit/contribution/equal-share/compensation) is the analytical engine.
- "Equity vs equality", reservation-adjacent stems -> route the general compensatory PRINCIPLE here; route the policy debate to the Caste owner.

MEMORY: Justice-first distinction = proportional (distributive) vs arithmetic (corrective); then name the criterion for the specific good in dispute.

EXAM APPLICATION 9 - Justice II: Rawls, Nozick, Sen, Ambedkar and the Ordering Verdict

The heaviest exam subtopic -- five owners live here.

- 2019 Q1(a), 10 marks -- is Rawls continuing Plato's justice -> continuity only in the broad sense that justice structures a well-ordered society; radical break in method, egalitarian citizenship and rejection of fixed hierarchy.
- 2021 Q1(a), 10 marks -- Nozick's distributive/entitlement theory -> historical vs patterned; Wilt Chamberlain; minimal state; concede acquisition/rectification weakness.
- 2021 Q2(a), 20 marks -- Sen an improvement on Rawls -> name the criterion, then adjudicate (niti/nyaya, capabilities, public reasoning).
- 2023 Q1(a), 10 marks -- justice as fairness -> original position, veil, two principles, priority rules.
- 2025 Q4(a), 20 marks -- equality and liberty inadequate without justice -> the ordering verdict is the whole answer.

MEMORY: For "is X an improvement upon Y?", the criterion of improvement must be named BEFORE you apply it.

EXAM APPLICATION 10 - Debates, Criticisms and Traps: Synthesis Across the Triad

- 2019 Q1(a), 10 marks -- Rawls continuing Plato -> a continuity/break comparison; fix axes (what is justice / unit of analysis / equality idea).
- Any "compare / distinguish" stem -> insert a 3-axis table and adjudicate.
- Any "critically evaluate" stem -> lead with the strongest objection, give the best reply, then a residual problem that survives the reply.

MEMORY: Directive first. "Discuss" = expose one live tension; "critically evaluate" = objection-reply is the answer; "how far" = degree judgment; "is X an improvement?" = name the criterion first.

Workbook Source Audit

- Exact PYQ wording, year and marks: local Socio-Political Philosophy Paper II bank, 2018-2025.
- Exactly 14 owner questions (2018:1, 2019:2, 2020:1, 2021:3, 2022:2, 2023:1, 2024:2, 2025:2).
- Ownership discipline: democracy-form questions (Forms of Government) and Marxism-as-ideology questions (Political Ideologies) are kept separate; the 2022 Q2(c) equity/equality part is routed to this owner (equity vs equality, Marx as frame). The affirmative-action policy debate is routed to the Caste (Gandhi-Ambedkar) owner.
- Model solutions authored at examiner grade: thesis -> named source / argument -> analysis -> objection/reply -> graded verdict, each closing with a "Why this earns marks" note.
- MCQs: 40 core plus 8 remedial, exactly 48, strict A-B-C-D rotation twelve times.
- Original Mains: one solved 10-marker, one solved 15-marker and one solved 20-marker.
- Provenance discipline observed throughout (Rawls 1971; Nozick 1974; Berlin 1958; Mill 1859/1869; Pettit 1997; Skinner 1998); named-scholar syntheses (non-domination module, distributive-criteria grid) carry no page/editing/quotation; Articles 14-16 are a constitutional permission, not a philosophical justification.
- No current-affairs anchor is used (no verified 2026 development forced); relevance is static and syllabus-driven.
- Final consolidated register notes are intentionally excluded from this workbook.

Practice Design

The workbook sequence is the fourteen exact verified PYQs -> 40 core MCQs -> 8 remedial MCQs -> original 10/15/20-mark Mains practice. There are no register notes and no canonical apparatus block in this workbook.

DIRECTIVE -> THESIS -> DOCTRINE -> NAMED SOURCE / EXAMPLE -> OBJECTION / REPLY -> VERDICT

SOLVED PYQ BANK - EXACTLY 14 VERIFIED OWNER QUESTIONS

Exact wording, year and marks are parsed from the local Socio-Political Philosophy Paper II bank for 2018-2025. This clause owns exactly 14 primary parts (2018:1, 2019:2, 2020:1, 2021:3, 2022:2, 2023:1, 2024:2, 2025:2). Ownership discipline: democracy-form questions owned by Forms of Government and Marxism-as-ideology questions owned by Political Ideologies are NOT counted here; the 2022 Q2(c) equity/equality part is routed to this owner because the demanded concept is equity vs equality (Marx supplies only the frame).

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q2(a), 20 marks

Question: How far can liberty and equality be considered as distinctive features of democracy ? Discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. Liberty and equality are **DISTINCTIVE** but not **EXHAUSTIVE** features of democracy: they constitute its normative core, yet each is indeterminate until justice and fraternity fix which liberties are basic and which equalities matter. "How far" therefore demands a degree-judgment, not a yes/no.

- **Liberty as a democratic feature.** Democracy institutionalises negative liberties (speech, association, dissent) and a positive, self-ruling liberty -- Rousseau's citizen obeys a law he helps author. Without protected liberty, elections are hollow.
- **Equality as a democratic feature.** Political equality (equal vote, equal eligibility for office) and social equality (absence of status hierarchy) give democracy its non-oligarchic standing. One-person-one-vote is itself an equality of civic worth.
- **Their relation (the mark-bearing move).** At the level of basic liberties the two **REINFORCE** (free speech for all is a liberty **AND** an equality); they conflict only beyond a threshold, where market liberty breeds inequality or aggressive equalising curbs choice. Rawls's lexical priority of equal basic liberties shows liberty need not be traded for aggregate welfare.
- **Qualification / limit.** Liberty and equality alone do not prevent majority tyranny, propaganda or the hollowing of political equality by social hierarchy. Ambedkar's warning is decisive: political democracy is unstable without **SOCIAL** democracy rooted in liberty, equality **AND** fraternity; justice supplies the ordering criterion.

Verdict. Liberty and equality are genuinely distinctive of democracy, but only as far as justice orders them and fraternity sustains them; beyond the threshold they need adjudication, so they are necessary features, not sufficient ones.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it treats "how far" as a degree question, shows the base-level complementarity **AND** the marginal conflict, and closes with the justice/fraternity supplement rather than one-sided praise.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2019 Q1(a), 10 marks

Question: How far do you think John Rawls is continuing with Plato's concept of justice?

Model solution

Thesis. Rawls continues Plato only in a broad architectonic sense -- justice as the virtue that structures a well-ordered whole -- and breaks with him radically on method, citizenship and equality. State the criterion of "continuity" first.

- **Continuity.** For Plato, justice is right-order: each part of soul and city performs its own function in harmony. For Rawls, justice is the first virtue of the basic structure -- fair terms of cooperation among free and equal persons. Both make justice the ORDERING virtue of the social whole, not one desire among others.

- **Break 1 -- method.** Plato reaches justice through the metaphysics of the Forms and functional differentiation; Rawls through a hypothetical device, the original position under a veil of ignorance -- a device of representation, not a cosmology.

- **Break 2 -- equality and citizenship.** Plato's order is a fixed hierarchy of natural kinds; Rawls builds in equal basic liberties and fair equality of opportunity for equal citizens, explicitly rejecting caste-like closure.

Verdict. The continuity is thin (justice as the structure of a good society); the discontinuity is deep (democratic-egalitarian method against fixed hierarchy). Rawls inherits Plato's QUESTION, not his ANSWER.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it names the axis of continuity before judging, and separates a shared question from opposed answers instead of forcing a single verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q4(b), 15 marks

Question: Does liberty put limitations to equality? Discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. Liberty limits equality only at the margin; at the level of basic liberties and equal civic standing the two reinforce each other. This is a "how far" stem, so the mark-bearing move is a conditional verdict.

- **Where liberty limits equality.** Unrestricted freedom of contract, property accumulation and market power let the strong dominate the weak, generating material inequality (Rousseau: convention converts difference into domination). Heavy protection of the private domain can block redistribution.

- **Where it does not.** Equal basic liberties ARE a form of equality; securing them for all is simultaneously a liberty and an equal civic standing. Rawls's priority rules permit inequality only under fair opportunity and benefit to the least advantaged, so liberty is not licence to entrench privilege.

- **The reframing (depth).** On the republican view, material dependence is itself DOMINATION; certain equalising measures therefore INCREASE freedom rather than trading against it -- the un-interfered-with dependent is still unfree. So "liberty vs equality" is not a zero-sum law.

Verdict. Liberty limits equality where market advantage expands unchecked, and supports it where basic liberties and non-domination are secured; the honest answer is a matter of degree, decided by justice.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it gives a genuine degree-judgment, deploys non-domination to dissolve the trade-off, and avoids a flat yes/no.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2020 Q1(a), 10 marks

Question: Is the concept of liberty realizable in the modern technological society? Explain.

Model solution

Thesis. Liberty is realisable in a technological society, but only under active vigilance against surveillance, manipulation and the concentration of informational power -- convenience is not autonomy.

- **The enabling case.** Technology expands knowledge, mobility, communication and choice; it can widen the effective capacity to act (a Green-style, enabling freedom).

- **The threat.** Modern coercion is infrastructural and informational, not only legal: algorithmic nudging can leave formal options open while shaping choices invisibly, and data concentration creates a standing capacity for arbitrary interference -- domination even without overt interference.

- **The condition of realisability.** Liberty survives if the system is transparent, accountable and contestable, preserving zones of non-domination; where it is opaque and unaccountable, formal freedom masks dependence.

Verdict. Liberty is realisable, but conditionally -- it is secured by transparency, accountability and non-domination, and endangered wherever convenience is mistaken for autonomy.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it answers the yes/no with a condition, distinguishes convenience from autonomy, and names the informational form of modern unfreedom.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2021 Q1(a), 10 marks

Question: Discuss critically the distributive theory of justice as propounded by R. Nozick.

Model solution

Thesis. Nozick's is a HISTORICAL (entitlement) theory, not a distributive one in the patterned sense: a distribution is just if it arose through just steps, whatever its final shape. Powerful as a warning, it is incomplete on its own premises.

- **Doctrine.** Justice in holdings has three principles -- justice in ACQUISITION (how unowned things are first justly held), justice in TRANSFER (voluntary exchange and gift) and justice in RECTIFICATION (correcting past injustice). There is no required end-state pattern.

- **Historical vs patterned.** Patterned principles (equality, need, merit) judge the shape of the distribution; historical principles judge the PROCESS. The Wilt Chamberlain argument shows that if people freely pay to watch him, the resulting inequality is just, and maintaining any fixed pattern would require continuous interference with voluntary transfers.

- **Critique.** The acquisition and rectification principles are the weakest links: both need an independent criterion, and real starting distributions are tainted by conquest, coercion and background injustice, so "voluntariness" is rarely clean.

Verdict. Nozick's side-constraint, self-ownership warning against overreaching redistribution is a permanent contribution; but because his own foundational principles are under-specified, entitlement theory cannot bypass the problem of unjust starting points.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it fixes the historical/patterned distinction, uses Wilt Chamberlain as argument (not decoration), and lands the critique on acquisition/rectification.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 Q1(b), 10 marks

Question: How does Rousseau distinguish between natural and artificial inequality ? Explain.

Model solution

Thesis. Rousseau distinguishes NATURAL (physical) inequality from MORAL or POLITICAL (artificial) inequality, and his point is diagnostic: the most oppressive inequalities are socially produced, not natural.

- **The distinction.** Natural inequality covers differences of age, strength, health and intelligence. Moral/political (artificial) inequality covers wealth, honour, power, dependence and social superiority -- established by convention.
- **The argument.** Natural differences become politically toxic only when institutions convert them into durable domination and vanity. Civil society -- above all property and the passion for comparison -- deepens dependence and manufactures hierarchy.
- **The nuance.** Rousseau does not say ALL inequality is conventional; he says the oppressive forms are socially created and maintained. The claim is diagnostic, not pastoral -- he is not romanticising nature.

Verdict. One person being stronger is natural; one person commanding another because convention sanctifies property and status is moral/political inequality -- and that, for Rousseau, is where injustice lives.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it states both terms precisely, explains the convert-difference-into-domination mechanism, and blocks the "romantic Rousseau" misreading.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2021 Q2(a), 20 marks

Question: Discuss whether Amartya Sen's idea of justice is an improvement upon Rawls's theory of justice.

Model solution

Thesis. Whether Sen improves on Rawls is CRITERION-RELATIVE: judged by attention to realised freedom and remediable injustice Sen improves on Rawls; judged by the need for determinate institutional principles Rawls retains the advantage. Name the test before applying it.

- **Rawls in brief.** A just basic structure chosen behind the veil of ignorance: equal basic liberties, fair equality of opportunity and the difference principle. Its focus is ideal, transcendental and institution-centred.
- **Sen's reorientation.** Sen contrasts NITI (correctness of rules and institutions) with NYAYA (justice realised in actual lives). A society may have fine rules yet produce grave injustice, so we should COMPARE feasible social states and remove manifest injustice rather than seek one perfectly just structure; the metric is CAPABILITIES, refined through PUBLIC REASONING.
- **The improvement, assessed.** By the criterion of realised freedom, Sen improves on Rawls -- primary goods ignore the diversity of conversion into real freedom, and transcendental design can neglect how people actually fare. But by the criterion of institutional determinacy, comparative ranking without an ideal benchmark can under-determine choice among rival improvements.
- **Rawlsian reply.** Institutions remain indispensable preconditions of justice; comparison still presupposes standards the ideal theory helps supply.

Verdict. Sen improves on Rawls in ORIENTATION (from arrangements to lives, from resources to capabilities), but does not simply supersede him; "improvement" holds only on a stated criterion, and both are needed.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it states the criterion of improvement first, uses niti/nyaya and capabilities as argument, concedes what Rawls still does better, and gives a criterion-relative verdict.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2022 Q1(d), 10 marks

Question: "Complete liberty may lead to inequality while order and restrictions imply a necessary loss of freedom." Critically discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. The statement states a real tension but overstates it: "complete liberty" does tend to inequality, yet order and restriction are not NECESSARILY a loss of freedom. Critically, the word "necessary" is where the claim fails.

- **First half -- true.** Unrestricted liberty (freedom of contract, unchecked property and market power) lets the strong dominate the weak; Rousseau shows how convention converts advantage into durable domination. So complete liberty can indeed generate inequality.

- **Second half -- only partly true.** On the negative view every law subtracts from liberty. But on the republican view NON-ARBITRARY law is FREEDOM-CONSTITUTING: it strips private persons of arbitrary power, so a contestable law that tracks citizens' interests can restrict WITHOUT reducing real freedom. Order can enable liberty rather than merely cost it.

- **Adjudication.** Both halves hold only BEYOND a threshold; at the level of basic liberties, order and freedom coincide. The dilemma treats a marginal trade-off as a law of all cases.

Verdict. Complete liberty risks inequality, and SOME restrictions do cost freedom -- but the claim that restriction NECESSARILY reduces freedom is false; just, contestable order can constitute liberty.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it attacks the modal word "necessary", uses the freedom-constituting-law point, and delivers a graded rather than either/or verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2022 Q2(c), 15 marks

Question: Explain the difference between the notion of equity and equality with reference to Marxian philosophy.

Model solution

Thesis. In Marxian philosophy, EQUALITY is the application of one common measure to all, while EQUITY is differentiated distribution responsive to real need; Marx's deeper claim is that formal equal right can be a right of INEQUALITY.

- **The distinction.** Equality = same standard for everyone (equivalent exchange among legal equals). Equity = shares differentiated by need and actual condition ("to each according to his need"). Equal treatment of unequally-placed people reproduces disadvantage.

- **Marx's argument.** Bourgeois equality abstracts from class structure. The wage contract LOOKS free and equal, but a right measured by a common standard is applied to people who differ in need, burden and family condition -- so equal right is, in content, a right of inequality; and the wage relation itself is structurally exploitative.

- **The two-stage caution.** The need-principle belongs to a HIGHER stage of cooperation where alienated labour and scarcity are transformed; it is not a market-time salary rule, and reading it as one invites the "vague / weakens incentive" objection.

Verdict. Equality and equity diverge because a single measure cannot be fair to unequal needs; Marx uses the distinction to expose the class content hidden beneath formally equal exchange.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it fixes the measure-vs-need distinction, roots it in the equal-right-as-right-of-inequality argument, and flags the higher-stage qualification without drifting into a Political-Ideologies essay.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2023 Q1(a), 10 marks

Question: What is meant by justice as fairness? Explain Rawls' theory of justice.

Model solution

Thesis. "Justice as fairness" means that the principles of justice are those that free and equal persons would choose under fair conditions; Rawls builds those conditions into the original position and derives two lexically ordered principles.

- **The device.** In the ORIGINAL POSITION, parties choose principles for the basic structure behind a VEIL OF IGNORANCE -- not knowing their class, sex, talents, religion or conception of the good. Ignorance of arbitrary advantage makes the choice fair; it is a device of representation, not a historical contract.

- **The two principles.** (1) Each has an equal claim to a fully adequate scheme of equal BASIC LIBERTIES. (2) Social and economic inequalities must satisfy (a) FAIR equality of opportunity and (b) the DIFFERENCE PRINCIPLE -- they may stand only if they benefit the LEAST ADVANTAGED.

- **Priority and justification.** Liberty is LEXICALLY prior (never traded for economic gain); fair opportunity precedes the difference principle. Justification proceeds by REFLECTIVE EQUILIBRIUM -- mutual adjustment of principles and considered judgments.

Verdict. Justice as fairness is a deontological liberal egalitarianism: liberty is basic, and inequality is tolerated only under fair opportunity and benefit to the least advantaged.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it defines fairness through the fair choice situation, states the principles with their PRIORITY, and adds reflective equilibrium rather than listing slogans.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2024 Q1(a), 10 marks

Question: Briefly discuss Plato's concept of justice.

Model solution

Thesis. For Plato, justice is not external distribution but ORDER and HARMONY: each part of the soul and each class of the city performing its own proper function without usurping another's.

- **Soul and city.** In the city, rulers rule, auxiliaries defend and producers provide; in the soul, reason governs spirit and appetite. Justice is the virtue that coordinates plurality into a harmonious whole.

- **What it is not.** Justice is not merely paying debts or obeying law; it is an inner and civic right-order grounded in functional differentiation and the rule of reason.

- **Criticism and reply.** Objection: Plato subordinates individuality to a fixed hierarchy. Reply: his aim is a norm of COMPETENCE and organic harmony, not arbitrary privilege -- though the closure of classes remains a real cost.

Verdict. Plato's justice is a powerful ideal of harmony and appropriate function; its enduring value is the insight that justice orders the whole, even if its fixed hierarchy is rejected by modern egalitarian citizenship.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it gives the soul-city parallel, distinguishes harmony from distribution, and balances the standard criticism with its reply.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2024 Q2(b), 15 marks

Question: Critically evaluate the concepts of liberty and equality as political ideals.

Model solution

Thesis. Liberty and equality are the twin political ideals of a free society, but each is powerful only when specified and disciplined; evaluated critically, they are complementary at the base and rivalrous at the margin, and both need justice.

- **Liberty, specified.** Negative liberty (freedom from interference) guards against coercion and paternalism; positive liberty (self-mastery) and the republican third family (non-domination) capture what mere non-interference misses. Objection: negative liberty can serve the already powerful -- true if isolated from fair background conditions.

- **Equality, specified.** Formal, political, social and economic equality, plus the modern question "equality of what?" (welfare, resources, capabilities). Objection: aggressive equalising can flatten choice and desert -- true only if it ignores thresholds, fair opportunity and capability floors.

- **Critical relation.** Equal basic liberties ARE an equality; conflict appears only beyond a threshold. Non-domination shows some equalisation INCREASES freedom (material dependence is domination). Rawls's priority rules keep liberty from being traded away while permitting justified inequality.

Verdict. As political ideals, liberty and equality are indispensable but INDETERMINATE alone -- each is silent about which liberties and which equalities matter; justice supplies the ordering criterion, so they are best defended together.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it specifies both ideals (three liberties, four equalities + the metric question), runs objection-reply on each, and closes with the ordering role of justice.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2025 Q1(e), 10 marks

Question: Discuss the salient features of equality according to J.S. Mill.

Model solution

Thesis. Mill is a QUALIFIED liberal egalitarian: he affirms equal moral and civic standing -- above all women's equality -- while resisting a crude levelling that would suppress individuality.

- **Salient features.** (1) Equal moral worth -- each person counts, none discounted by birth. (2) Equality before law and citizenship -- privilege by status is indefensible. (3) WOMEN'S equality -- in The Subjection of Women the legal and social subordination of women is a relic of domination, not nature. (4) Equality compatible with INDIVIDUALITY -- sameness is not the goal, free self-development is. (5) Hostility to custom-made hierarchy. (6) A qualified economic concern -- open to reforming property and labour relations, not to coercive levelling.

- **The core argument.** A society that excludes half its members or attaches rights to status wastes human capacities and violates utility properly understood; the "nature" invoked to justify subordination is itself socially manufactured through subjection.

- **Limit.** Mill remains too individualist to reach structural economic inequality -- but within liberalism he radicalises equality by extending it from formal rights to social relations, especially gender.

Verdict. Mill's equality is equality of STATUS, RIGHTS and CHANCE compatible with liberty and individuality -- egalitarian in worth and gender, restrained in economics.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it lists Mill's features precisely, foregrounds the feminist argument and the individuality proviso, and states the structural limit rather than over-claiming.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2025 Q4(a), 20 marks

Question: How are both equality and liberty inadequate as social and political ideals without justice? Discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. Equality and liberty are indispensable but INADEQUATE by themselves, because each is indeterminate about its own content; justice is the architectonic ideal that supplies the ordering criteria and decides their scope and priority.

- **Why liberty alone is inadequate.** "Liberty" does not tell us WHICH liberties are basic, or how to weigh one person's freedom against another's. A tyrant and a citizen both invoke freedom; negative, positive and republican conceptions pull apart. Only a theory of justice ranks basic liberties and protects them (Rawls's lexical priority).
- **Why equality alone is inadequate.** "Equality" is under-specified -- of status, rights, opportunity, welfare, resources, capability or outcome? Each metric yields different institutions, and without a criterion, equality collapses into either mechanical levelling or empty formalism.
- **What justice supplies.** Justice provides the adjudicatory criteria -- desert, fairness, entitlement, need, capability, rectification and public reason -- that say which inequalities are justified and which liberties are basic. They also require fair procedures: an impartial process cannot cleanse an unjust starting structure, while substantive correction cannot dispense with hearing, publicity and consistent limits. Compare the positions: liberty-first (Nozick) protects self-ownership but lets background injustice hollow real freedom; equality-first levelling flags oppression but flattens choice and desert; justice-as-ordering balances them by principle.
- **Indian anchor.** Ambedkar: political democracy (equal votes, formal liberty)
is unstable without SOCIAL democracy -- liberty, equality AND fraternity -- so justice must reach lived social standing, not only procedure.

Verdict. Liberty and equality are the substance of a just society, but justice is its FORM: it is the ideal that disciplines and coordinates the other two, and without it each remains normatively incomplete.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it proves inadequacy by showing each ideal is indeterminate about its own content, compares three ordering positions, anchors in Ambedkar, and ends with the architectonic verdict.

Three original questions authored for this package (not PYQs), one each at 10, 15 and 20 marks, with full model solutions.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains 1

Original 10-marker - Social and Political Ideals - approx. 150 words.

Question: Distinguish formal equality from substantive equality. Can formal equality itself entrench substantive disadvantage? Answer in 150 words.

Model solution

Thesis. Formal equality (identical treatment under identical rules) and substantive equality (equal real standing and capability) can diverge, and formal equality applied to unequally-placed people can freeze existing disadvantage.

- **Formal equality.** Equality before the law and equal application of rules; necessary against arbitrary privilege.

- **Substantive equality.** Equal effective freedom to participate and flourish - Sen's capability register, not mere legal identity.

- **How formal equality entrenches disadvantage.** A single common measure ignores unequal starting points; "the same rule for all" can ratify an unequal race (Rousseau's converted inequality; Marx's "equal right is a right of inequality"). Formal equality is then a floor, not the whole of equality.

Verdict. Formal equality is indispensable but incomplete; substantive equality supplies what identical treatment cannot, so justice must decide when equal treatment requires differentiated response.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks - it fixes the two senses precisely, names the mechanism of entrenchment, and grades formal equality as necessary-but-partial rather than dismissing it.

Original Mains 2

Original 15-marker - Social and Political Ideals - approx. 250 words.

Question: Berlin distinguished two concepts of liberty. Is a third concept of liberty needed? Critically examine. Answer in 250 words.

Model solution

Thesis. Berlin's negative/positive pair is powerful but incomplete; the republican concept of freedom as NON-DOMINATION captures an unfreedom neither of Berlin's concepts sees, so a third concept is defensible - though it can be partially absorbed by a demanding negative liberty.

- **Berlin's pair.** Negative liberty = absence of interference; positive liberty = self-mastery. Berlin's warning: positive liberty invites a coercive "higher self".

- **The gap.** On a pure interference-count, a slave with an indulgent master is "free" because not currently interfered with. Intuitively he is unfree: he must defer, flatter and self-censor because the master CAN interfere arbitrarily. Neither non-interference (there is none) nor self-mastery (the point is external) explains this.

- **The third concept.** Freedom as non-domination = absence of another's standing CAPACITY for arbitrary interference. Interference is an act; domination is a status. Non-arbitrary, contestable law becomes freedom-constituting.

- **Objection and reply.** A Berlinian may say non-domination is just a high probability of future interference - reducible to negative liberty. Reply: probability can be LOW precisely where dependence is total, and domination also explains the dependent's own deference, which a bare interference-count cannot. Concede that the boundary of "arbitrary" remains contestable.

Verdict. A third concept earns its place by naming dependence as unfreedom; whether it is genuinely irreducible or a refined negative liberty is the live debate - the defensible answer is a qualified "yes".

MEMORY: Why this earns marks - it states Berlin accurately, uses the un-interfered-with dependent as argument, gives objection-reply, and returns a qualified verdict rather than a flat one.

Original Mains 3

Original 20-marker - Social and Political Ideals - approx. 250 words.

Question: 'Justice is the architectonic political ideal that orders liberty and equality.' Critically evaluate. Answer in 250 words.

Model solution

Thesis. The statement is largely defensible: because liberty and equality are each indeterminate about their own content, justice supplies the ordering criteria that fix their scope and priority - though "architectonic" must not be read as justice replacing the other two.

- **Why liberty is indeterminate.** "Liberty" does not say which liberties are basic or how to weigh one person's freedom against another's; negative, positive and republican conceptions pull apart. Rawls's lexical priority of equal basic liberties is a JUSTICE-supplied ranking.

- **Why equality is indeterminate.** "Equality of what?" - status, opportunity, resources, welfare, capability - yields different institutions. Without a criterion, equality collapses into mechanical levelling or empty formalism.

- **What justice supplies.** Desert, fairness, entitlement, need, capability, rectification and public reason - the criteria that say which inequalities are justified and which liberties are protected. Compare orderings: Nozick (liberty-first) protects self-ownership but lets background injustice hollow real freedom; crude equality-first flattens choice and desert; Rawlsian justice-as-ordering balances them by principle. Ambedkar adds that political liberty and equality are unstable without fraternity and social democracy.

- **Objection and reply.** Objection: this inflates justice into a master-value and demotes liberty/equality to mere inputs. Reply: justice is the FORM, not a rival substance - it orders the very ideals it presupposes; without them there is nothing to order.

Verdict. Justice is architectonic in the ordering sense: liberty and equality are the substance, justice the discipline - each incomplete without the others.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks - it proves the thesis by demonstrating the indeterminacy of both ideals, compares three ordering positions, meets the master-value objection, and lands a precise architectonic verdict.

Answer-specific execution and compression upgrades

These controls follow the detailed models and make each one executable in the timed paper.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q2(a), 20 marks - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **How**. Address this exact question: *How far can liberty and equality be considered as distinctive features of democracy ? Discuss*. Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *How far can liberty and equality be considered as distinctive features of democracy ? Discuss*. rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: about 300 words: thesis, six developed moves, named comparison, strongest objection/reply, India-linked application where relevant and a graded conclusion. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2019 Q1(a), 10 marks - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **How**. Address this exact question: *How far do you think John Rawls is continuing with Plato's concept of justice?* Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *How far do you think John Rawls is continuing with Plato's concept of justice?* rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: 150 words: verdict-led definition, three analytical moves, one precise qualification and a direct close. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q4(b), 15 marks - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **Does**. Address this exact question: *Does liberty put limitations to equality? Discuss*. Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *Does liberty put limitations to equality? Discuss*. rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: 220-250 words: thesis, four or five claim-evidence-analysis moves, one objection/reply and a qualified verdict. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2020 Q1(a), 10 marks - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **Is**. Address this exact question: *Is the concept of liberty realizable in the modern technological society? Explain.* Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *Is the concept of liberty realizable in the modern technological society? Explain.* rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: 150 words: verdict-led definition, three analytical moves, one precise qualification and a direct close. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2021 Q1(a), 10 marks - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **Discuss**. Address this exact question: *Discuss critically the distributive theory of justice as propounded by R. Nozick.* Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *Discuss critically the distributive theory of justice as propounded by R. Nozick.* rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: 150 words: verdict-led definition, three analytical moves, one precise qualification and a direct close. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 Q1(b), 10 marks - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **How**. Address this exact question: *How does Rousseau distinguish between natural and artificial inequality? Explain.* Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *How does Rousseau distinguish between natural and artificial inequality? Explain.* rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: 150 words: verdict-led definition, three analytical moves, one precise qualification and a direct close. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2021 Q2(a), 20 marks - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **Discuss**. Address this exact question: *Discuss whether Amartya Sen's idea of justice is an improvement upon Rawl's theory of justice*. Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *Discuss whether Amartya Sen's idea of justice is an improvement upon Rawl's theory of justice*. rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: about 300 words: thesis, six developed moves, named comparison, strongest objection/reply, India-linked application where relevant and a graded conclusion. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2022 Q1(d), 10 marks - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **the stated directive**. Address this exact question: *"Complete liberty may lead to inequality while order and restrictions imply a necessary loss of freedom." Critically discuss*. Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *"Complete liberty may lead to inequality while order and restrictions imply a necessary loss of freedom." Critically discuss*. rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: 150 words: verdict-led definition, three analytical moves, one precise qualification and a direct close. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2022 Q2(c), 15 marks - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **Explain**. Address this exact question: *Explain the difference between the notion of equity and equality with reference to Marxian philosophy*. Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *Explain the difference between the notion of equity and equality with reference to Marxian philosophy*. rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: 220-250 words: thesis, four or five claim-evidence-analysis moves, one objection/reply and a qualified verdict. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2023 Q1(a), 10 marks - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **What**. Address this exact question: *What is meant by justice as fairness? Explain Rawls' theory of justice*. Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *What is meant by justice as fairness? Explain Rawls' theory of justice*. rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: 150 words: verdict-led definition, three analytical moves, one precise qualification and a direct close. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2024 Q1(a), 10 marks - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **Briefly discuss**. Address this exact question: *Briefly discuss Plato's concept of justice*. Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *Briefly discuss Plato's concept of justice*. rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: 150 words: verdict-led definition, three analytical moves, one precise qualification and a direct close. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2024 Q2(b), 15 marks - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **Critically evaluate**. Address this exact question: *Critically evaluate the concepts of liberty and equality as political ideals*. Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *Critically evaluate the concepts of liberty and equality as political ideals*. rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: 220-250 words: thesis, four or five claim-evidence-analysis moves, one objection/reply and a qualified verdict. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2025 Q1(e), 10 marks - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **Discuss**. Address this exact question: *Discuss the salient features of equality according to J.S. Mill.* Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *Discuss the salient features of equality according to J.S. Mill.* rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: 150 words: verdict-led definition, three analytical moves, one precise qualification and a direct close. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2025 Q4(a), 20 marks - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **How**. Address this exact question: *How are both equality and liberty inadequate as social and political ideals without justice? Discuss.* Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *How are both equality and liberty inadequate as social and political ideals without justice? Discuss.* rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: about 300 words: thesis, six developed moves, named comparison, strongest objection/reply, India-linked application where relevant and a graded conclusion. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Original Mains 1 - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **Distinguish**. Address this exact question: *Distinguish formal equality from substantive equality. Can formal equality itself entrench substantive disadvantage? Answer in 150 words.* Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *Distinguish formal equality from substantive equality. Can formal equality itself entrench substantive disadvantage? Answer in 150 words.* rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: 220-250 words: thesis, four or five claim-evidence-analysis moves, one objection/reply and a qualified verdict. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Original Mains 2 - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **the stated directive**. Address this exact question: *Berlin distinguished two concepts of liberty. Is a third concept of liberty needed? Critically examine. Answer in 250 words.* Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *Berlin distinguished two concepts of liberty. Is a third concept of liberty needed? Critically examine. Answer in 250 words.* rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: 220-250 words: thesis, four or five claim-evidence-analysis moves, one objection/reply and a qualified verdict. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.

Original Mains 3 - timed-paper upgrade

Directive and demand decoding: The operative demand is **the stated directive**. Address this exact question: *'Justice is the architectonic political ideal that orders liberty and equality.'* Critically evaluate. Answer in 250 words. Do not replace it with a general topic summary.

How to improve this answer: State the conclusion in the opening; turn each major claim into **claim -> named thinker/text/example -> analysis -> qualification**; preserve the model's strongest objection and reply; and make the final sentence answer *'Justice is the architectonic political ideal that orders liberty and equality.'* Critically evaluate. Answer in 250 words. rather than merely repeat the doctrine.

Executable exam-length/compression guidance: 220-250 words: thesis, four or five claim-evidence-analysis moves, one objection/reply and a qualified verdict. Cut decorative biography and repeated definitions first; never cut the governing distinction, named evidence, objection or verdict.